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UNDER FIRE: Attacks have increased along the LoC

the ceasefire as well as that of the LoC".

Defence sources say the latest ceasefire violation is the second in Kashmir since November 2003. "This is for the first time since 1998 that Pakistani troops have crossed the LoC and fired on the Indian positions," says army spokesman Lt-Colonel A.K. Mathur. India has lodged a protest with the Pakistan army.

Army officials say Pakistani troops usually fire on Indian positions to facilitate militant infiltration from their side. This cross-border attack comes amid fresh spurt in violence including IED and grenade attacks across Kashmir Valley ahead of assembly elections due in November this year.

by Aljaz Hussain

Football Fever

KOLKATA The growing Indian economy and lucrative sponsorship deals have made the Australian Football League (AFL) gravitate towards India, a country that Australian former cricket captain Steve Waugh used to refer to as "the final frontier". The sport, hugely popular in Australia, was started by

SUVASHIS MULLICK



KICK OFF: An AFL team

cricketers in 1858 to stay fit in the off-season. About 600 players in 16 teams play AFL in 12 venues. But almost every Australian kid, who has a sporting bone in his body, plays the sport, claims cricketer Ricky Ponting, who is the AFL's ambassador in India.

AFL has grand plans for India and an amateur Indian team has already been formed which will travel to Australia. They are training in Kolkata and will leave on August 22 to participate in an international amateur competition. The team will play in Warrnambool and Melbourne as part of the 150th year celebrations of the AFL. The team is drawn from kabaddi, basketball, football and rugby players. Ponting believes that Indians, who like their football, can play this game. At what level, though, remains a million dollar question.

by Elora Sen

Line of Losing Control

SRINAGAR Guns have started roaring again along Kashmir's frontiers after the official ceasefire that was declared in November 2003. The recent months have also witnessed a rise in infiltration from across the border while Indian and Pakistani troops have traded gunfire six times in the past three weeks.

On July 28, over a dozen Pakistani soldiers crossed over into the Indian side of the LoC in northern Kupwara after an altercation with five Indian soldiers and opened fire around 3.30 p.m. One Indian and four Pakistani soldiers were killed in what the army authorities call "brazen and biggest violation of

Free at Last

BANGALORE The good, the bad and the ugly have been here. Today's NDA convener George Fernandes and BJP leader L.K. Advani were locked up here in 1975 when they opposed the Emergency. Actors like Kamal Hasan and Amitabh Bachchan shot films here 20 years ago. The British tortured Indian protesters during the reign of the Empire. The 22-acre Bangalore Central Jail, established in 1867 by the then British government in the heart of Bangalore, has seen it all.

Six years ago, the state Government decided to move the jail to city outskirts and create a "free-

B K RAMESH



CHANGING FACE: The Central Prison

dom park" at the old prison with an amphitheatre, an information corridor, a sculpture court and a pavilion block, among other things. The central tower, barracks and the jail entrance block will be retained as heritage structures. The watchtower will be a souvenir shop.

Prisons are some of the

oldest institutions in the state, most of them being over a century old. "If they were mute witnesses to history and were home to grim tales, it is good to know the Bangalore city corporation is planning to set the concept of freedom in a new way," says legislator Dinesh Gundu Rao.

by Stephen David